

Book II - The Spiral and the Block

Part 3 - The Eight Pillars

Chapter 24 - Pillar III - Power Corrupts Centralized Systems

PILLAR 3 — Power Corrupts Centralized Systems

Series: Eight Pillars **Core Idea:** Every great tradition warns against the concentration of authority. Not as a moral preference — as a systems observation.

The Thesis

"Power corrupts" is not a cynical modern observation. It is one of the oldest and most consistently encoded warnings in human wisdom tradition.

From Jotham's parable in Judges 9 to the Buddha's teaching on attachment to authority, from the prophets' warnings against kings to the Tao Te Ching's suspicion of rulership — every tradition that has survived long enough to matter has encoded the same observation:

Centralized power is unstable. It corrupts what holds it. And systems built around centralized power eventually collapse.

This is not a moral claim. It is a systems observation. Cancer is not evil. It is a cell that forgot its role.

Source Material

From *The Spiral Steward*:

"When a single component elevates itself above the rest — when one cell stops cooperating and starts demanding — the system collapses. Cancer is not a foreign invader. It is a cell that forgot its role.

Empire is systemic cancer. Monoculture is ecological cancer. Centralized control, applied to systems that require distributed intelligence, is organizational cancer."

"The thornbush makes a terrible king, because thorns were never meant to rule. They were meant to protect, to contain, to define edges, to defend life. A thorn doing the work of a thorn is essential. A thorn trying to be a crown is catastrophic."

From *The Sagent Creed*: "Evil, understood as the deliberate manufacture of division and suffering for the purposes of control, cannot be defeated by those who adopt its methods."

How the Traditions Express This Pillar

Judaism — Samuel and the King (1 Samuel 8): The people demand a king. Samuel warns them exactly what a king will do: take your sons for war, your daughters for service, your fields for taxation, your freedom for compliance. God tells Samuel: "It is not you they have rejected. It is me they have rejected as their king." The original anti-monarchy text. Written into the founding document of Western civilization. And ignored at every opportunity since.

Christianity — "My Kingdom Is Not of This World": Jesus consistently refused political power. Fled when crowds tried to make him king (John 6:15). "Render unto Caesar" — not endorsing Rome, but refusing to let Rome's categories define him. The early church's refusal to worship the emperor: not sedition, but a refusal to let any human power claim ultimate authority over conscience.

Taoism — The Smaller the Government, the Better: Laozi: "Governing a large state is like cooking a small fish" — handle it as little as possible. "The best rulers are those the people barely know exist." The Tao Te Ching is deeply suspicious of large, active, interventionist government — not on libertarian grounds, but because intervention disrupts the living order that emerges naturally.

Buddhism — The Poison of Power: The Buddha's teaching on the three poisons: greed, hatred, delusion. Concentrated power amplifies all three simultaneously. The bodhisattva ideal refuses worldly authority precisely to remain in service to all beings — because accepting power over others corrupts the capacity to serve them.

Stoicism — Virtue Cannot Be Given or Taken: Marcus Aurelius — one of the most powerful men who ever lived — wrote the Meditations as a daily practice of refusing to be corrupted by his power. The Stoic observation: external power over others is not a good. Only virtue is a good. And virtue is impossible to sustain in direct proportion to unchecked authority.

The Living Age Connection

The One Ring cannot be used safely — even by Gandalf, even by Galadriel. The centralized authority that corrupts is not a fantasy. It is a systems property. The more authority concentrates, the more it must protect itself from challenge — and the more it corrupts in the process of protecting itself.

The Living Age doesn't ask for better rulers. It asks for different architecture. Not blocks with better block-heads. Spirals that don't require the block at all.

Source Quotes

Direct quotes from Sage's own writing to draw from when scripting this episode.

"The ruler king is an agent of satan and the leader king is an agent of god. In the kingdom of Satan there is a chain of command that goes through man — and everyone fights to go up the command structure. But this structure isn't heavenly and the top isn't good but evil."

"When they created the king by force God said they have rejected me as their king."

"Ephesians 6:12 — 'For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places.' — Our greatest enemies are not physical rulers, governments, or individuals — but the unseen systems, ideologies, and spiritual forces that shape reality."

"The monopoly on force and the debt-based banks to back it up. Both corrupted of their true roots — a Republic of conscience and free banking based on a commodity."

"When dismantling an evil organization you must not be evil yourself or all you will do is prune the branches. Pruning the branches only makes it stronger. It must be taken out by the roots."

"Republic went right into Palpatine's trap because they were willing to do things that didn't seem right to their conscience — but they believed if they didn't they might lose more. But what is anything else without your conscience?"

"The illuminati is the dark side of the force — it is the Phantom Menace, the ones working in the shadows creating conflicts that if you fight head on you fall right into their trap."